that are suspected of being used by China to gather intelligence in India. A classified note was also given to top officials about a Chinese institute planning to open branches in Tamil Nadu and West Bengal. China also exploits the legitimate cover of business in sectors like telecom, engineering and manufacturing.

A seasoned spy said:

China is replicating the espionage method of using soft power under the cover of legitimate activities which had earlier been patented by the US and Russia. The Chinese are using academics, scholars, businessmen, professionals and even journalists to mount operations in India. In recent years, it has been noticed by the counterintelligence

team that Chinese firms have emerged as the lowest bidders in many infrastructural projects in India, with the active support of the Chinese government. Such Chinese footprints are increasingly being noticed in states like Maharashtra, Chhattisgarh and Haryana. They are also targeting strategic locations. For example, a Chinese business delegation went to Betul Island in Goa, near INS Khadamba. Espionage threats are also emanating from non-Chinese firms which employ Chinese persons as happened with the Dhamara Port Company in Odisha, which is strategically located near Dr Abdul Kalam Island, earlier known as 'Wheeler' Island.

Since that meeting, the government has begun examining business proposals from Chinese companies from the espionage angle. However, the threats have not disappeared. The then home minister, Rajnath Singh, during a closed-door meeting in 2018 where the R&AW chief was also present, asked a pertinent question: Why is there a large scale presence of Chinese